TECH, EXPLAINED

Why old customer data breaks on import

The same problems show up in almost every spreadsheet.

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5. A tip for owners

Vishan Amarnath · Co-founder & CTO, Bizzzauto

Tamil names turn into junk

Read a file with the wrong text encoding and every Tamil name breaks.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

தமிழ் → à®¤à®®à®¿à®´à¯

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One number, written five ways

To a person, one number. To a computer, several customers.

ALL THE SAME NUMBER

- +91 98765 43210
- +919876543210
- 098765 43210
- 91-98765-43210
- 9876543210

One customer, three records

Once numbers are clean, duplicates show up. Merge them: one customer, one record.

Columns with different names

“Mobile”, “Phone No” and “Contact” mean the same thing. Match by meaning, not position.

A tip for owners

Saving from Excel? Choose “CSV UTF-8”. Plain CSV can lose Tamil letters before the file leaves your computer.

THE RULE

Clean data is the floor everything stands on.

1. Detect the encoding first
2. One format for every number
3. Merge the duplicates
4. Match columns by meaning
5. Save as CSV UTF-8

How messy is your customer list?

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